



ICELANDERS

EUROPE'S REMOTE ISLAND NATION

A MASS OF VOLCANIC ROCK in the middle of the north Atlantic Ocean, Iceland's inaccessibility meant that for centuries contact with the rest of the world was infrequent. In its isolation the country developed its own

Water, water everywhere

As well as being an island, Iceland has a lot of inland water, most famously hot springs, which are a major tourist attraction. The word *geyser* means a spurting, hot spring and comes from Geysir, the place in southwest Iceland where a spurt was first recorded in 1294. Geysers are caused by geothermal energy, the natural heat from the Earth that also causes volcanoes to erupt. In fact, geothermal energy formed this island in the first place.



GEOTHERMAL ENERGY

The Svartsengi power station takes in steam from naturally boiling seawater, heated by molten lava 6,000 ft (2,000 m) below the ground. The energy is used to heat freshwater for domestic use, or to drive turbines to create electricity. Using geothermal energy is clean and efficient, and, unlike resources such as natural gas, the water will never run out.



AN IMPORTANT SKILL

All children in Iceland learn how to swim, a skill that adults use frequently too. Iceland's outdoor swimming pools are open all year round. The weather might turn cold, but at 84°F (29°C), the naturally hot water keeps people warm.



CAPITAL CITY

The first settlers came to Iceland from Norway in the ninth century. They named the city they founded Reykjavik, or "Smoky Bay" because of the steam rising from the hot springs. Over 60 percent of Iceland's population live in or around Reykjavik, the world's most northerly capital.

